

Saturday, 18 July 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON Overcast 23° 17°	BIRMINGHAM Overcast 22° 14°	MANCHESTER Overcast 22° 14°	GLASGOW Partly cloudy 23° 14°
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01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

- 1

A mother has been jailed for trying to hide the knife used to kill student Henry Nowak, in a shocking twist to the case.

Kiran Kaur was sentenced after attempting to remove the weapon from the murder scene. This development adds another layer to the tragic death of young Henry Nowak.

CRIME · UK
- 2

China has strongly criticised the UK government's decision to nationalise British Steel, calling it a significant move.

The government stated that taking the firm into public hands was essential to safeguard a 'vital national capability'. This has sparked an international reaction from Beijing.

BUSINESS · UK
- 3

Parts of England are experiencing their longest dry spell in 30 years, as the current heatwave extends into its second week.

While all UK nations have seen recent hot conditions, southern England has now endured 14 consecutive days of heat. The prolonged dry weather is raising concerns.

WEATHER · UK
- 4

Good news for parents: energy drinks will be banned for under-16s in England starting next April.

This new law will make it illegal to sell high-cafeine beverages to children. However, soft drinks with lower caffeine levels will not be affected by the ban.

HEALTH · UK
- 5

Andy Burnham's 'Manchesterism' strategy helped him become Prime Minister, but now the question is whether it can work for the whole country.

Economics editor Faisal Islam is examining if the north-west city can truly serve as a national template. It's a big test for the new leader's vision.

POLITICS · UK

What's coming up

- 1 A brand new photograph has been released to mark Queen Camilla's 79th birthday today!**
Her Majesty is celebrating with a renewed commitment to supporting children's literacy initiatives. It's a lovely way to mark the occasion.
| ON AIR – What's your favourite royal tradition or celebration?
ROYALTY · TODAY
- 2 Heartstopper stars Kit Connor and Joe Locke say making the Netflix film will 'forever be important' to them.**
The movie brings Alice Oseman's incredibly popular screen adaptation to a conclusion. Fans are buzzing to see how the story wraps up.
| ON AIR – Are you a fan of Heartstopper? What are you hoping for in the final film?
FILM · COMING UP
- 3 Linkin Park is set to make history as the first female-fronted band to headline Download Festival!**
It's a huge moment for the festival, sparking debate about whether it's a milestone or a 'bittersweet' moment. Either way, it's big news for rock fans.
| ON AIR – Is this a long-overdue moment for Download, or does it not matter who headlines?
MUSIC · COMING UP
- 4 A union is calling for GTA 6 maker Rockstar to address working conditions ahead of the game's highly anticipated release.**
They're urging for better working conditions and pay transparency within the company. It's a big topic as the gaming world gears up for one of its biggest launches.
| ON AIR – Are you excited for GTA 6? Do you think game developers should have more support?
GAMING · COMING UP
- 5 Jesy Nelson has called the plan to test newborns for a life-limiting muscle condition a 'victory'.**
All newborn babies in England are now set to have a heel prick test for Spinal Muscular Atrophy (SMA). It's a significant step forward for early diagnosis.
| ON AIR – It's wonderful news for families, isn't it? Do you remember the heel prick test for your children?
HEALTH · NOW

On the schedule

1 **Two golfers have equalled the lowest rounds in men's major history at The Open, but with very different reactions!**

Australia's Lucas Herbert and America's Sam Burns both shot incredible eight-under 62s. Herbert was gutted after a bogey on the 18th, while Burns holed out from a bunker!

ON AIR – What a round of golf! Have you ever had a moment where you've been both thrilled and gutted about a sporting achievement?

GOLF · UK

2 **Joe Root has once again stepped up for England, hitting an unbeaten 99 to level the ODI series against India.**

His fantastic innings guided England to a four-wicket win in Cardiff. It means it's all to play for in the final match of the three-game series.

ON AIR – Joe Root is so reliable, isn't he? Who's the most dependable player in your favourite team?

CRICKET · UK

3 **England Rugby captain Jamie George says the team is considering walking off the pitch if players face racial abuse in Argentina.**

It's a strong stance against potential racism during their upcoming match. This highlights the ongoing fight against discrimination in sport.

ON AIR – It's a powerful statement, isn't it? Do you think walking off is the right way to tackle racial abuse in sport?

RUGBY · UK

4 **Great news for Liverpool fans: midfielder Dominik Szoboszlai has signed a new five-year deal at Anfield!**

This commitment secures his future with the club for the foreseeable future. It's a big boost as the new season approaches.

ON AIR – Fantastic news for Liverpool! Which player would you most like your club to sign up for the long term?

FOOTBALL · UK

5 **West Ham captain Jarrod Bowen is set to stay at the club for the forthcoming season, despite their relegation.**

It's a strong show of loyalty from the captain, committing to the team in the Championship. Fans will be relieved to hear this news.

ON AIR – It's great to see a captain stick with his team through thick and thin, isn't it? What does loyalty mean to you in sport?

FOOTBALL · UK

Quick hits

- 1 A recent study suggests that listening to the gentle rumble of a distant train can be surprisingly soothing.**
Researchers found that for many, the rhythmic sound evokes a sense of calm and nostalgia, providing a gentle background to daily life.
- 2 The simple joy of 'cloud watching' is making a delightful comeback as a mindful pastime.**
People are rediscovering the imaginative fun of spotting shapes in the sky, a relaxing activity perfect for a sunny afternoon.
- 3 More people are embracing the charm of 'vintage board games' for family entertainment.**
Classic titles from decades past are being dusted off, offering a nostalgic and screen-free way to connect and compete.
- 4 The humble 'garden shed' is transforming into a creative sanctuary for many across the UK.**
From art studios to reading nooks, these small spaces are becoming cherished retreats for hobbies and quiet reflection.
- 5 A delightful trend sees people 'exchanging handwritten recipes' with friends and family.**
It's a personal touch that connects generations and keeps beloved family dishes alive, often with notes and anecdotes.
- 6 The surprising popularity of 'collecting interesting pebbles' from beaches and riverbanks is growing.**
Many find joy in the hunt for uniquely shaped or coloured stones, often using them for home decor or as small keepsakes.
- 7 Experts are highlighting the unexpected benefits of 'taking a leisurely walk without a destination'.**
This aimless wandering encourages spontaneous discovery and can significantly boost mood and creativity.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q Our survey said that over 60% of us admit to secretly 'doing' what when we're trying to fix a small household item, even if we know it's unlikely to help?

ANSWER: GIVING IT A FIRM TAP OR A GENTLE SHAKE!

Q Our survey said that over 55% of us admit to having a particular 'lucky item' they absolutely have to carry with them on a day they want to go well. What is it?

ANSWER: THAT PARTICULAR FADED COIN, A SMOOTH STONE, OR A TINY CHARM.

TALK TOPIC

- **You know how sometimes a particular 'sound' can instantly transport you back to a specific memory or a moment from your past?**
What's that sound for you, and where does it take you? Is it the jingle of the ice cream van, the distant whistle of a train, or perhaps the creak of a particular garden gate?
- **We all have those 'little rituals' we perform without even thinking, especially when we're getting ready for something important.**
Do you have a specific way you arrange your workspace before starting a big task, or a particular order you get dressed in for a special occasion? What are your little pre-event traditions?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **Nature.** Did you know that flamingos get their pink colour from the food they eat? Their diet of brine shrimp and algae contains pigments called carotenoids that turn their feathers pink.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** Did you know that the common garden snail can sleep for up to three years at a time without waking, surviving on stored energy?

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£9.5 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£9.5 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- The world's smallest mammal is the bumblebee bat, found in Thailand and Myanmar.
- A group of ferrets is officially called a 'business'.
- The 'unicorn' is the national animal of Scotland.
- Honey never spoils; archaeologists have found pots of honey in ancient Egyptian tombs that are still edible.
- There are more permutations to shuffle a deck of cards than there are atoms on Earth.
- Mount Everest grows by about 4 millimetres each year due to tectonic plate movement.
- The human eye can distinguish approximately 10 million different colours.
- It takes about 8 minutes for light from the Sun to reach Earth.

On this day

Day 199 of the year, 166 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Arnulf of Metz; Christian feast day: Bruno of Segni; Christian feast day: Camillus de Lellis (optional memorial, United States only); Christian feast day: Eadburh (or Edburga) of Bicester. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1961 — Elizabeth McGovern, American actress
- 1954 — Ricky Skaggs, American singer-songwriter, mandolin player, and producer
- 1982 — Ryan Cabrera, American singer-songwriter and guitarist
- 1975 — Daron Malakian, American singer-songwriter, guitarist, and producer
- 1967 — Vin Diesel, American actor, director, producer, and screenwriter
- 1934 — Darlene Conley, American actress (died 2007)
- 1985 — Chace Crawford, American actor
- 1932 — Robert Ellis Miller, American director and screenwriter (died 2017)

THE DAY TODAY

- 1925 — Adolf Hitler publishes Mein Kampf.
- 1994 — Rwandan genocide: The Rwandan Patriotic Front takes control of Gisenyi and north western Rwanda, forcing the interim government into Zaire and ending the genocide.
- 1996 — Battle of Mullaitivu: The Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam capture the Sri Lanka Army's base, killing over 1,200 soldiers.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1942 — The Germans test fly the Messerschmitt Me 262 using its jet engines for the first time.
- 2013 — The Government of Detroit, with up to \$20 billion in debt, files for the largest municipal bankruptcy in U.S. history.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1984 — McDonald's massacre in San Ysidro, California: James Oliver Huberty kills 21 people and injures 19 others before being shot dead by police.
- 1996 — Battle of Mullaitivu: The Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam capture the Sri Lanka Army's base, killing over 1,200 soldiers.

- 1968 — Intel is founded in Mountain View, California.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 200 of the year, 165 days left in 2026. Today Palace Day; Christian feast day: Aurea of Córdoba; Christian feast day: Bernold, Bishop of Utrecht; Christian feast day: John Plessington. Star sign Cancer, birthstone Ruby.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1992 — Jake Nicholson, English footballer
- 1983 — Helen Skelton, English television host and actress
- 1961 — Campbell Scott, American actor, director, and producer
- 1944 — Tim McIntire, American actor and singer (died 1986)
- 1998 — Erin Cuthbert, Scottish footballer
- 1950 — Freddy Moore, American singer-songwriter and guitarist (died 2022)
- 1937 — Richard Jordan, American actor (died 1993)
- 1947 — Bernie Leadon, American guitarist and songwriter

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 2011 — Guinean President Alpha Condé survives an attempted assassination and coup d'état at his residence in Conakry.
- 1957 — The largely autobiographical novel *The Ordeal of Gilbert Pinfold* by Evelyn Waugh was published.
- 1972 — Dhofar Rebellion: British SAS units help the Omani government against Popular Front for the Liberation of Oman rebels in the Battle of Mirbat.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1989 — United Airlines Flight 232 crashes in Sioux City, Iowa, killing 111.
- 1979 — The oil tanker SS Atlantic Empress collides with another oil tanker, causing the largest ever ship-borne oil spill.

Coming to cinemas

JULY 2026

FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

JULY 2026	
4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
AUGUST 2026	
W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)